

The Incredible Maya Angelou

If you don't know who Maya Angelou is, you should! She was an American author, poet, and civil rights activist. Not only was she an incredibly talented writer, but she was also a powerful advocate for the rights of African Americans. Let's take a look at her amazing life and why she is still so revered today.

Early Life & Education

Maya Angelou was born in St. Louis, Missouri on April 4th 1928 as Marguerite Ann Johnson. At the age of three she and her brother were sent to live in Stamps, Arkansas with their grandmother. In Stamps, Angelou learned about resilience from her grandmother's strength and fortitude as well as from the hardships of the Jim Crow South. After returning to her mother in St. Louis at the age of eight, Angelou attended George Washington High School for two years before leaving school to become the first female streetcar conductor in San Francisco.

Writing & Activism

Angelou's writing career began when she joined the Harlem Writers Guild during the 1950s where she wrote plays and screenplays with fellow writers such as James Baldwin and Lorraine Hansberry. In 1969, Angelou published *I Know Why The Caged Bird Sings* — a book that would later become her most well-known work — which tells her story growing up in Arkansas during the Jim Crow era of racial segregation and discrimination against African Americans in America. Since then she has written over 30 books including five autobiographies which are all focused on how racism affects people's lives both emotionally and physically. Additionally, Dr. Maya Angelou served on two presidential committees during Bill Clinton's presidency and worked hard to advocate for many different causes ranging from gender equality to education reform throughout her life.

Legacy

Dr. Maya Angelou left behind an incredible legacy; not only did she write some of the most influential works in American literature but also worked tirelessly to promote civil rights around the world until her death in 2014 at age 86. Her contribution to literature has been recognized numerous times by institutions such as Harvard University awarding her an honorary degree or President Obama awarding her with the Presidential Medal of Freedom recognizing all that she accomplished throughout her life advocating for justice and equality for all people regardless of their race or gender identity..

Maya Angelou made a lasting impact on our country through both her writing and activism that continues even after her passing away six years ago at age 86. Her autobiography *I Know Why The Caged Bird Sings* is still read by 8th grade students across America today because it is an important reminder about resilience even when faced with racism or oppression. We owe it to ourselves to remember Dr. Maya Angelou's tireless work towards justice and equality for everyone - no matter their color, race, or gender. She will continue to inspire future generations!